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April 15, 2025

Abstract (preliminary)

This study investigates the impact of superstar players on WNBA game attendance, focusing on the Indiana Fever as a primary case. Prompted by the unprecedented public interest following the 2024 drafting of Caitlin Clark, the analysis explores how the arrival of highly visible athletes influences fan turnout. Drawing on event study regressions, lead-lag analysis, and dynamic treatment effect estimation, the paper analyzes game-level attendance data spanning multiple seasons and franchises. The findings reveal substantial variation in superstar impact: while Clark's arrival triggered an immediate and significant surge in attendance, the 2018 drafting of Kelsey Mitchell, despite her strong on-court performance, did not produce a comparable increase. These results suggest that media visibility, cultural relevance, and timing may play a critical role in shaping the commercial impact of elite players. The study contributes to a broader understanding of how star power influences audience behavior and provides actionable insights for teams, leagues, and marketers seeking to grow professional sports.

Introduction

On April 15, 2024, the Indiana Fever selected Caitlin Clark as the first overall pick in the WNBA Draft. Whether or not someone closely follows women's basketball, he or she has likely heard the name "Caitlin Clark" or seen her picture across major media platforms. Within days, the Fever saw a dramatic shift since her drafting: ticket sales spiked, social media engagement surged, and weeks later, the Fever's road games were drawing record-breaking crowds in opposing cities, and home games at Gainbridge Fieldhouse saw unprecedented demand. Clark, who brought a massive national following from her collegiate career at Iowa, had shown that this is not only a

new chapter for the Fever but also potentially a new era for the league. This moment demonstrated how a single player can reshape the visibility and commercial dynamics of a professional sports league.

Research Question

The central research question guiding this study is:

How does the presence of superstar players impact game attendance across seasons and teams?

To address this research question, the study analyzes game-level attendance data across multiple seasons, with a particular focus on the Indiana Fever as a case study. Three empirical strategies are employed: event study analysis, lead-lag regressions, and dynamic treatment effect estimation. These methodologies allow for the identification of both immediate shifts in attendance following a player's arrival and the evolution of attendance patterns over subsequent seasons. By constructing indicators around key events, such as player draft years, the analysis estimates the short-term and longer-term impacts of high-profile athlete acquisitions on fan engagement.

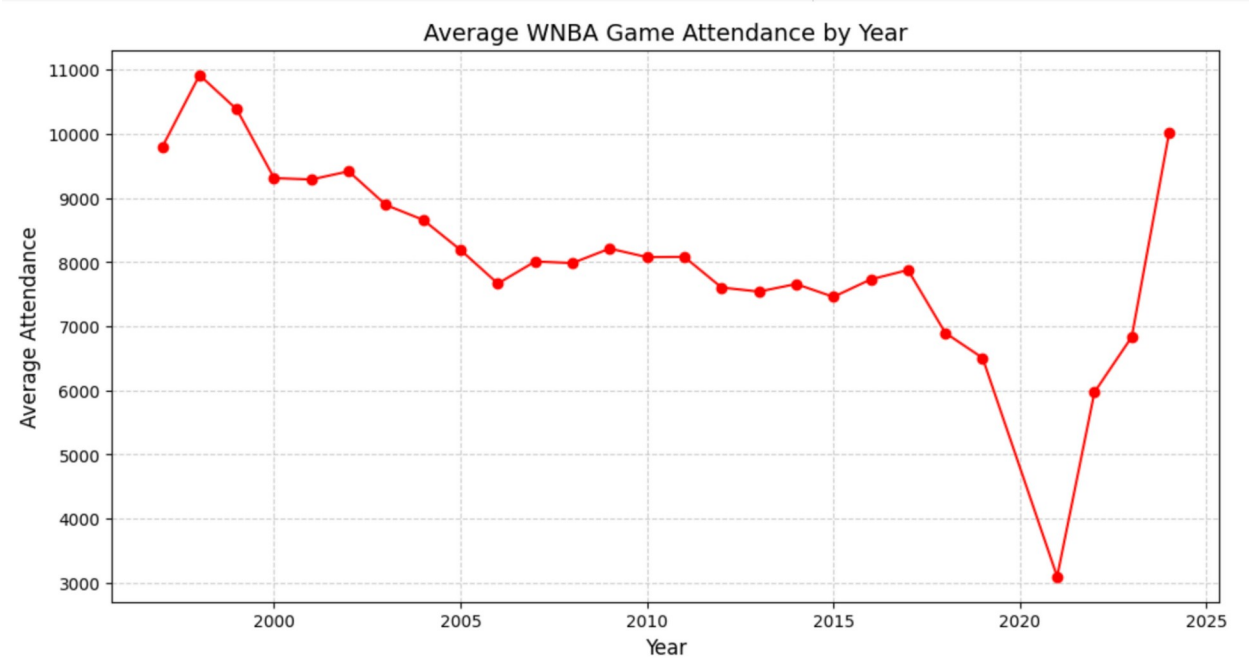
Results indicate that while the drafting of certain players, such as Caitlin Clark in 2024, led to a dramatic and immediate surge in attendance, not all superstar arrivals generated similar effects. For example, the Indiana Fever's 2018 draft of Kelsey Mitchell, although significant from a performance perspective, did not produce a comparable spike in fan turnout. These findings suggest that the impact of superstars is heterogeneous, as athletic excellence alone does not fully explain variations in attendance, and factors such as media visibility and public narrative play substantial roles.

Related Literature

- These are the papers
    - This is what they did
        - AND this is how it connects to my paper

Recent literature on superstar effects provides important context for understanding these dynamics. Azoulay, Graff Zivin, and Wang (2010) in their *Superstar Extinction* paper emphasize that a superstar's impact often extends beyond direct performance to include broader social and cultural influence. In the context of the WNBA, a player's media visibility, fan base, and social capital may play critical roles in boosting attendance beyond what on-court performance alone would predict. Similarly, Berri and Krautmann (2013) explore the economic challenges and stagnant attendance patterns in the WNBA, highlighting that despite promotional efforts, attendance has remained relatively flat. This suggests that the emergence of a visible superstar may offer a rare opportunity to disrupt lackluster fan engagement trends. Additionally, Montgomery and Robinson (2013) discuss how demographic factors and sports capital shape fan behavior, offering a lens to assess how superstar players might differentially attract various audience segments, particularly among women. Finally, Brown (2011) provides insights into how the presence of superstars can psychologically affect both competitors and broader engagement. While her focus is on competitor effort, parallels can be drawn to fan behavior: superstars may either enhance excitement and attendance or, if dominance seems inevitable, reduce the perceived competitiveness of games. Together, these works offer a nuanced theoretical and empirical foundation for analyzing how superstars shape attendance patterns in professional sports, particularly within emerging leagues like the WNBA.

Data



The dataset for this study is from [Across the Timeline], a repository of WNBA statistics. This platform offers detailed game-level attendance figures, team statistics, and league-wide data spanning from the league's inception in 1997 through the 2024 season. The dataset encompasses regular-season and playoff games, providing a robust foundation for analyzing attendance trends over time. Each entry in the dataset corresponds to a single game and includes information such as:

- ***Date***: The specific date of the game
- ***Home Team***: The team hosting the game
- ***Game Type***: Regular season and playoffs
- ***City and State, Arena***: Game location
- ***Attendance***: The number of spectators present at each game

To focus the analysis, the data was filtered to include games played between 1997 and 2024, but only for teams that qualified for the 2024 WNBA playoffs. Superstar players were identified based on ESPN’s 2024 coverage and rankings. The analysis centers on home games to better isolate the effects of team-led marketing and local fan engagement, which are more directly influenced by the presence of superstars.

Data Cleaning and Transformations

Some cleaning and transformation steps were applied to the raw data:

- **Attendance Filtering**: Games with missing attendance values were removed from the dataset. Accurate attendance figures are critical for correctly estimating superstar impact.
- **Seasonal Gaps Due to COVID-19**: There were no recorded games in the dataset for the 2020 WNBA season, as the COVID-19 pandemic caused the league to hold a shortened season in a "bubble" environment without fans in attendance. As a result, 2020 is omitted from attendance-based analyses.
- **Team-Specific Missing Data**: The Indiana Fever are missing attendance data for the 2021 season. Games involving the Fever in 2021 were excluded from the analysis to prevent bias introduced by missing values.
- **Date Parsing**: The "Date" field was standardized into a uniform datetime format to enable chronological calculations and event-based analysis relative to draft events.

Descriptive Statistics

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics

Home Team	*Mean*	*SD*	*Min*	*Max*
Atlanta Dream	5170	2459	561	17608
Connecticut Sun	6709	1662	2012	19125
Indiana Fever	8031	3267	960	18345
Las Vegas Aces	7238	3330	1954	20366
Minnesota Lynx	8355	2882	1934	19521
New York Liberty	9851	4295	815	19563
Phoenix Mercury	9331	2566	3618	17747
Seattle Storm	8001	2548	1001	18343

Descriptive Insights

From Table 1, it can be seen that attendance levels vary significantly across teams. The **New York Liberty** recorded the highest average attendance (9,851 fans per game), followed closely by the **Phoenix Mercury** (9,331) and the **Minnesota Lynx** (8,355). In contrast, the **Atlanta Dream** posted the lowest average attendance, with a mean of 5,170 fans per game. These differences highlight notable disparities in market size, fan engagement, and possibly the presence of superstar players across franchises.

Attendance variability within teams is also substantial, as shown by the relatively large standard deviations. For example, the **Las Vegas Aces** and **New York Liberty** exhibit standard deviations above 3,300 and 4,200, respectively, suggesting that attendance at their games fluctuated considerably across seasons or in response to special events, such as the drafting of high-profile players or playoff contention.

Overall, the descriptive statistics confirm that WNBA attendance is not uniform across teams or seasons and suggest that specific player acquisitions, local market characteristics, and broader league dynamics likely play crucial roles in influencing fan turnout. These insights motivate the more detailed regression analysis conducted in the following sections.

Methodology

This study employs multiple empirical strategies to estimate the effect of superstar players on WNBA game attendance. The primary identification challenge is separating the causal impact of a player's arrival from other factors that also affect attendance, like team performance and seasonal trends. To address this, three approaches were used: an event study design, a lead-lag model, and a dynamic treatment effect estimation using a difference-in-differences (DiD) framework with fixed effects.

Event Study

Through the event study method, I can isolate the impact of a specific event, whether it be a draft pick, a trade, or a free agency signing, on WNBA game attendance. Therefore, I utilized a time-series analysis to evaluate the impact of key superstar acquisitions on attendance. I filtered the main dataset to include only games where the team of interest was the home team. Then, I created a dictionary to mark important player acquisition dates, whether it be draft dates, trade dates, or free agency dates. For each player acquisition event, the code calculates a time variable, **t**, which measures the number of days before or after the superstar's arrival. It then creates a dummy variable, **After**, to indicate whether each game occurred before or after the player's arrival, and an interaction term, **t_After**, to allow the slope of the attendance trend to change after the event. An OLS regression is then estimated with Attendance as the dependent variable and the three time-related variables (**t**, **After**, and **t_After**) as predictors.

The model takes the form:

- is the attendance at game on day
- is the number of days relative to the draft date
- is a binary variable equal to 1 if the game occurred after the draft
- is an interaction capturing post-draft time trends

This model estimates both the immediate change in attendance after a player's arrival () and whether attendance continues to trend upward or downward post-draft (). This event study framework helps isolate short-term causal effects tied directly to the draft.

Lead & Lag Analysis

I also performed a lead-lag study to analyze how the arrival of WNBA superstars impacted game attendance over longer periods of time. This analysis helps identify whether each superstar generated an immediate or lasting boost in fan turnout. I filtered

the dataset to include only home games for each team of interest, then defined the specific dates when each player joined the team via draft, trade, or free agency. For each player, it calculates how many days and years each game occurred before or after their acquisition. Then, for a time window ranging from two years before to five years after the player's arrival, the code creates dummy variables to indicate each individual year relative to the joining event. By doing this, I can compare the players' year -2, year -1, year 0 to year 1, year 0 to year 2, year 0 to year 3, These variables are used in an ordinary least squares (OLS) regression to estimate the effect of each year on game attendance, allowing for a clear comparison to a baseline period. The model's results are then visualized using a bar plot for each player, offering a clear picture of attendance trends over time.

The model takes the form:

- is a set of indicator variables for $\in \{-2, -1, 1, 2, 3, \ldots\}$ years relative to the draft
- estimates the average attendance difference in year relative to the reference year

Dynamic Treatment Effect Estimation

To evaluate how attendance changes over time in response to a specific event, I use a dynamic treatment effect estimation within a panel data framework. This approach involves creating year-specific indicator variables for treated units, capturing whether an observation belongs to the treatment group in a given year. One year, typically the year of treatment, is omitted from the model and serves as the reference category, allowing all other years to be interpreted relative to it. I estimate a fixed effects panel regression that includes both entity effects to control for team-specific differences and time effects to account for broader year-to-year trends across the league. The resulting coefficients

represent the estimated effect of treatment in each year, and are plotted with 95% confidence intervals to illustrate the dynamics of the treatment effect over time.

The model takes the form:

- are team (entity) fixed effects
- are year (time) fixed effects
- are binary variables equal to 1 if team is treated in year , 0 otherwise
- measures the treatment effect in year relative to a base year (draft year)

This model enables estimation of dynamic causal effects of superstar presence over time while controlling for unobserved heterogeneity across teams and years. It is particularly useful for evaluating the sustainability of a superstar's impact and comparing multiple treatment cohorts, as teams acquire different stars in different years. Clustered standard errors are used to address serial correlation within teams. The “treatment” in this context is the drafting or signing of a superstar player, and the timing of treatment varies by team, allowing for a staggered DiD design.

Results

Results (Event Study)

Regression results indicate that most teams experience higher attendance figures after a superstar was drafted. However, there is variation across franchises, with some teams showing more significant attendance boosts than others. Additionally, external factors such as outside media deals, arena capacity, and team win-loss records may moderate these effects. To illustrate these dynamics in more detail, I will focus on the findings for the Indiana Fever.

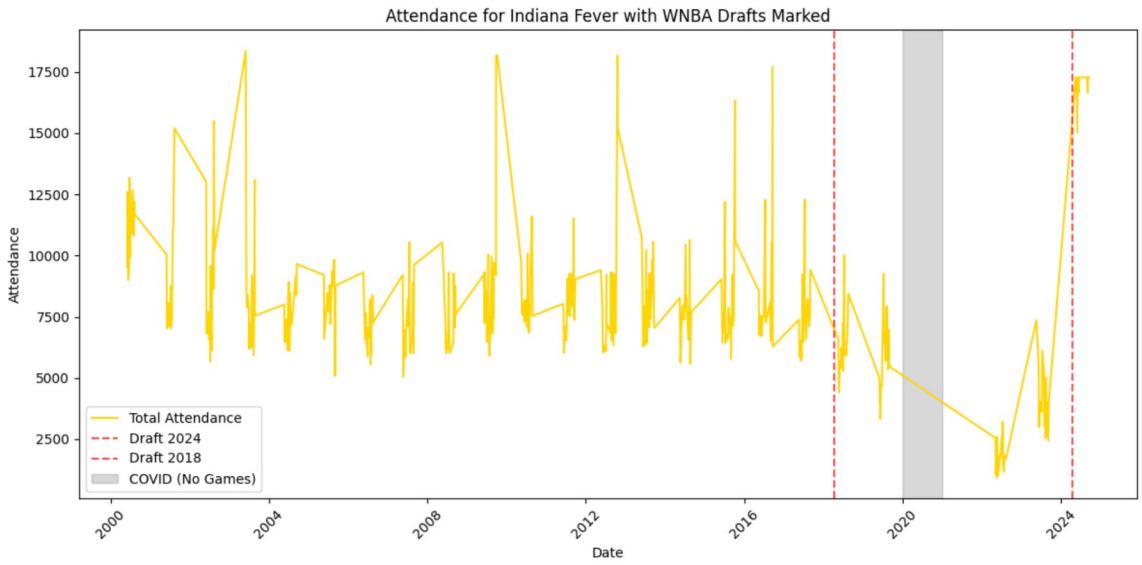


Table 2. Event Study Regression Results (Indiana Fever)

Draft Year	*Variable*	*Coefficient*	*Std. Error*	*P-value*	*Interpretation*
2024	*t*	–0.537	0.047	<0.001	Decline in attendance pre-draft
	After	11,540	1,241	<0.001	Immediate post-draft surge
	t x After	5.03	11.56	0.664	No significant post-draft trend
2018	*t*	–0.161	0.091	0.077	Slight pre-draft decline
	After	–3,956	683	<0.001	Drop in attendance post-draft
	t x After	2.75	0.389	<0.001	Gradual increase over time

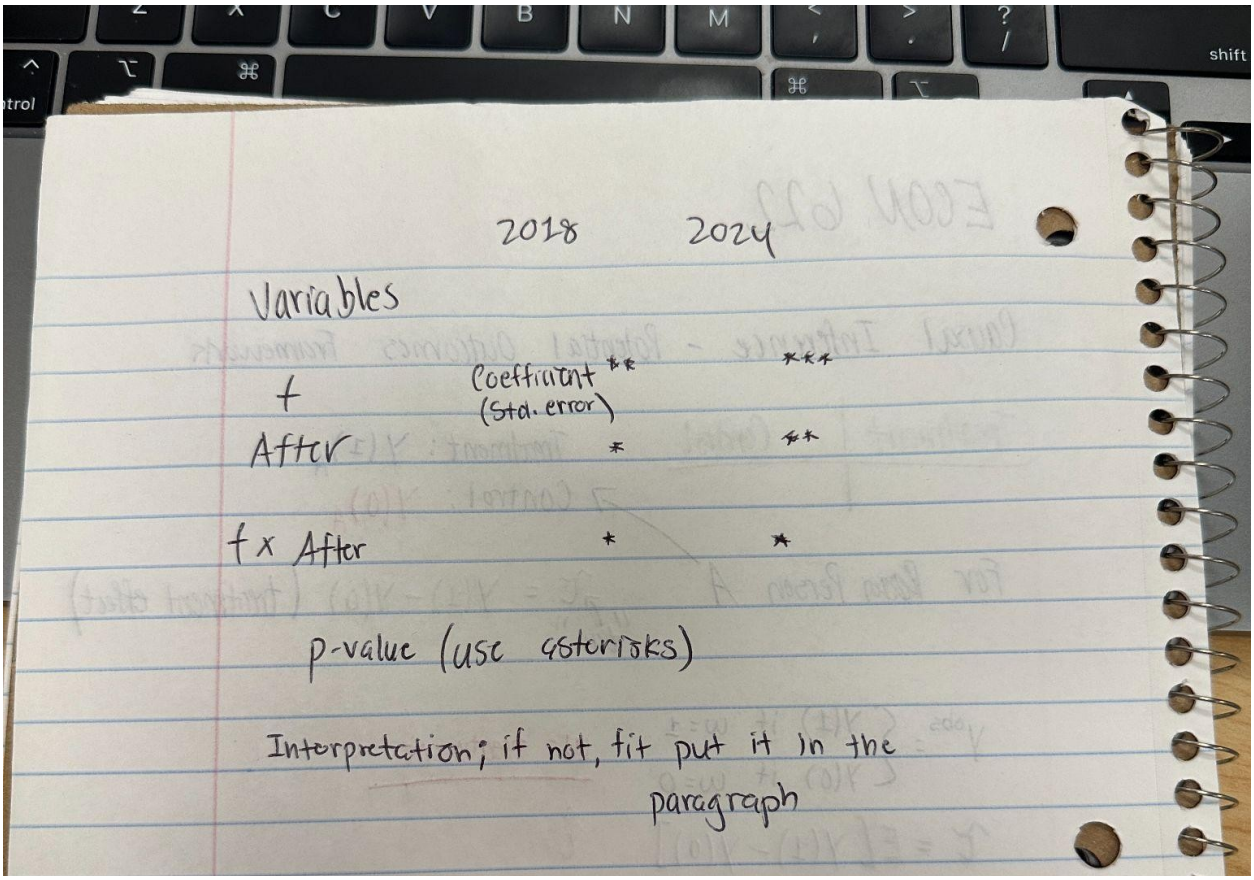


Table 2. Event Study Regression Results (Indiana Fever)

Variable	*2018*	*2024*
t	–0.161* (0.091)	–0.537*** (0.047)
After	–3,956*** (683)	11,540*** (1,241)
t x After	2.75*** (0.389)	5.03 (11.56)

The regression results for the Indiana Fever in 2024 show a dramatic and immediate impact on home game attendance following the WNBA draft. Prior to the draft, attendance was declining at a rate of approximately 0.54 fans per day ($p < 0.001$),

represented by ***t***, indicating a significant downward trend in fan interest. However, after the draft, shown by ***After***, attendance surged by an average of 11,540 fans per game ($p < 0.001$), a highly significant and substantial increase. The interaction term ***t_After*** is equal to 5.03 ($p = 0.664$), which was not statistically significant, suggesting that the increase was immediate rather than part of a longer-term trend. This sharp jump in attendance likely corresponds to the drafting of Caitlin Clark, whose widespread popularity and media attention generated historic interest and reversed the prior decline. In contrast, the 2018 draft did not produce a similar effect. Attendance showed a slight, statistically insignificant decline leading up to the draft, as ***t*** is equal to -0.161 ($p = 0.077$), and immediately afterward, attendance actually dropped by nearly 4,000 fans per game, represented by ***After*** ($p < 0.001$). However, there was a gradual increase in attendance over time following the draft, with an estimated gain of 2.75 fans per day, as shown by ***t_After*** ($p < 0.001$), indicating a slow recovery. This suggests that the 2018 draft did not generate an immediate spike in fan turnout and that any positive effects emerged more gradually, potentially due to a less publicized or slower-developing player presence.

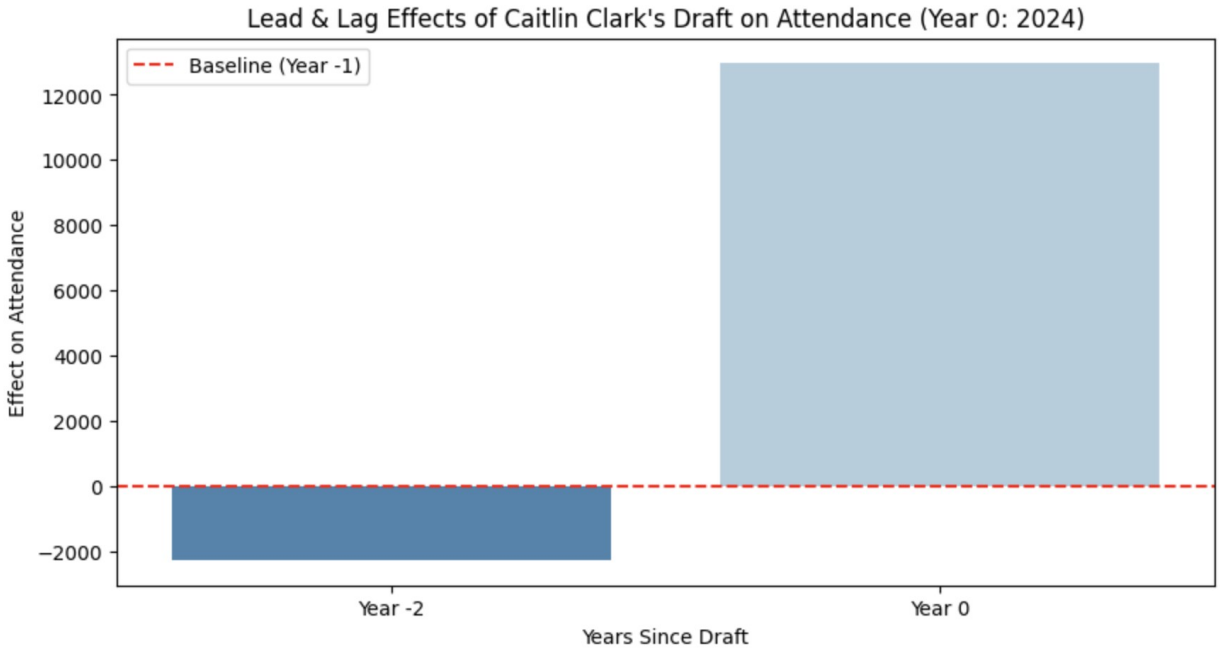
Results (Lead-lag Analysis)

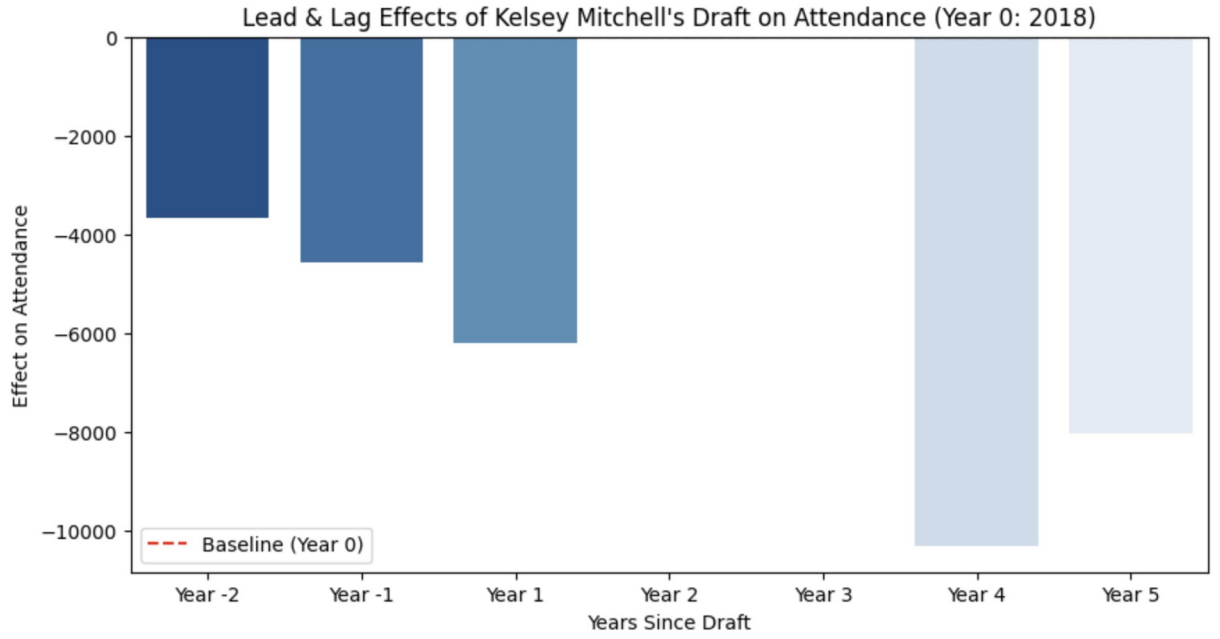
I will continue to use the Indiana Fever as a case study.

Table 3. Lead-Lag Regression Estimates (Indiana Fever)

Year Relative to Draft	*Clark (2024)*	*Mitchell (2018)*
Year –2	–2,291	–3,661
Year –1	Baseline	–4,571
Year 0	+12,970	Baseline
Year 1	—	–6,221
Year 2	—	Missing (COVID)
Year 3	—	Missing (2021)
Year 4	—	–10,330

Year 5	—	–8,042





Regression results show that Caitlin Clark's 2024 draft had a dramatic and immediate impact on Indiana Fever home game attendance. In the year she was drafted (Year 0), attendance increased by approximately 12,970 fans per game compared to the previous year ($p < 0.001$). This surge is statistically significant and substantial, representing one

of the largest single-year jumps in attendance observed in the dataset. The data also indicates that attendance was already beginning to trend upward prior to her arrival, with Year –2 showing attendance about 2,291 fans lower than the baseline (Year –1). The baseline year for Clark is Year –1 because Clark was drafted in 2024 and there are no games in the following years. This upward trajectory, combined with the overwhelming spike in Year 0, suggests that Clark's presence not only continued but amplified growing fan interest. In the visualization, I set the baseline year to 2023, as it represents the final full season before Caitlin Clark's arrival and offers the most relevant point of comparison for measuring immediate change. Additionally, since there is no attendance data available beyond 2024 at the time of this analysis, using 2023 as the baseline ensures that the comparison captures the full context of the shift without relying on incomplete or future data.

The 2018 draft of Kelsey Mitchell shows that attendance (Year 1) declined by 6,221 fans per game compared to the baseline year ($p < 0.001$), with negative and statistically significant coefficients extending across all years from Year –2 through Year +5. The accompanying visualization illustrates this downward trend, highlighting a consistent decline in attendance both before and after her draft year. It's also important to note that data is missing for Year 2 and Year 3, due to the COVID-19 pandemic and a gap in attendance records for the 2021 Indiana Fever season. Despite Mitchell's talent, the data suggest that her draft did not spark an increase in fan engagement at the same level, and that other contextual factors, such as team performance, media attention, or broader league trends, may have played a role in limiting her immediate commercial impact.

Results (Dynamic Treatment Effect Estimation)

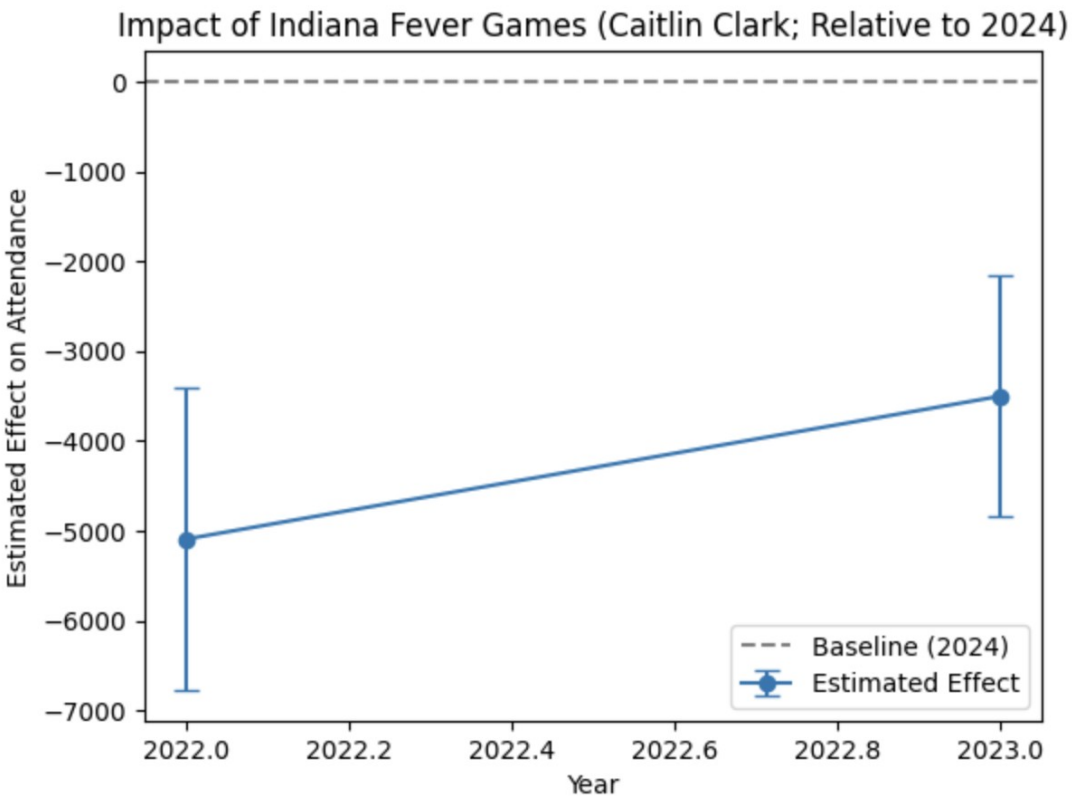
Table 4A. Dynamic Treatment Estimates – Caitlin Clark (Baseline Year: 2024)

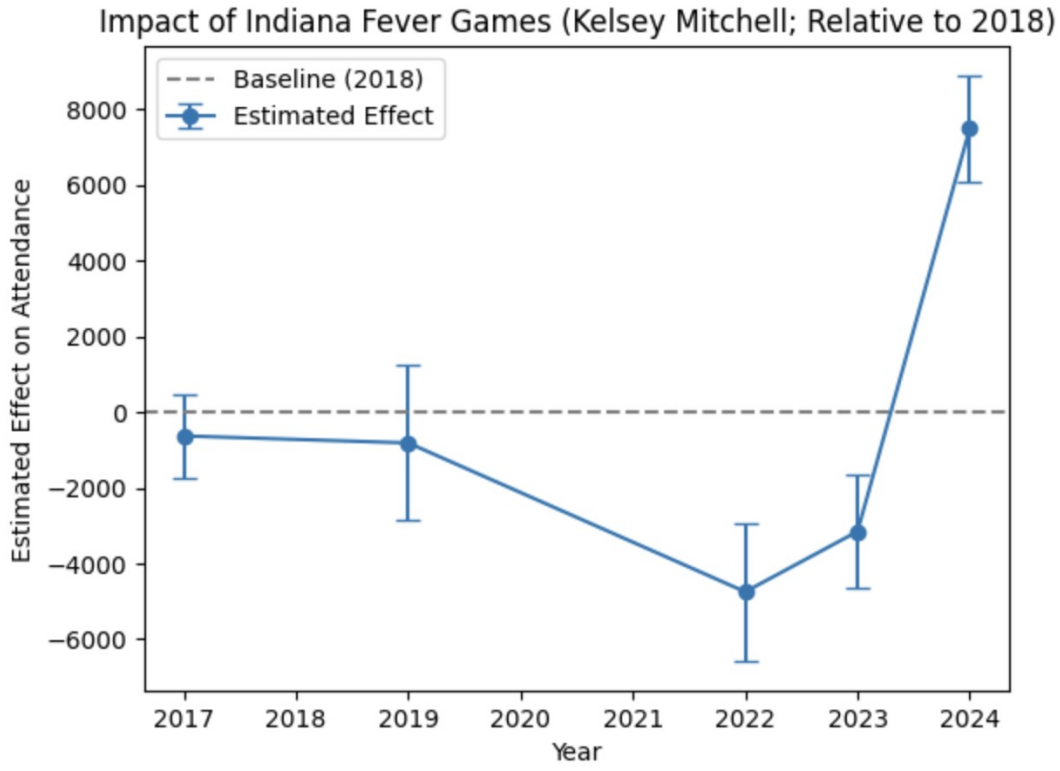
Year Compared to 2024	*Estimate*	*P-value*	*Interpretation*
2022	–5,095	<0.001	Significant pre-draft

			decline
2023	–3,502	<0.001	Significant pre-draft decline

Table 4B. Dynamic Treatment Estimates – Kelsey Mitchell (Baseline Year: 2018)

Year Compared to 2018	*Estimate*	*P-value*	*Interpretation*
2017	–631	0.265	Not significant
2019	–817	0.436	Not significant
2020	Missing (COVID)	Missing (COVID)	—
2021	Missing (2021)	Missing (2021)	—
2022	–4,749	<0.001	Significant post-draft decline
2023	–3,156	<0.001	Significant post-draft decline
2024	+7,494	<0.001	Large and significant attendance surge


Impact of Indiana Fever Games (Caitlin Clark; Relative to 2024)
Estimated Effect on Attendance
0
−1000
−2000
−3000
−4000
−5000
−6000
−7000
2022.0
2022.2
2022.4
2022.6
2022.8
2023.0
Year
Baseline (2024)
Estimated Effect


Impact of Indiana Fever Games (Kelsey Mitchell; Relative to 2018)
Estimated Effect on Attendance
8000
6000
4000
2000
0
−2000
−4000
−6000
2017
2018
2019
2020
2021
2022
2023
2024
Year
Baseline (2018)
Estimated Effect

These panel regression results indicate that attendance at the Indiana Fever games in 2022 and 2023 was significantly lower compared to the baseline year of 2024. Specifically, games in 2022 saw a decrease of approximately 5,095 fans per game ($p < 0.001$), while 2023 games experienced a decline of about 3,502 fans per game ($p < 0.001$). These effects are statistically significant, even after controlling for both team-level and year-level fixed effects.The results suggest a notable increase in attendance in 2024, likely due to the Fever drafting Caitlin Clark, with previous years reflecting comparatively lower fan turnout.

These results estimate dynamic treatment effects on attendance across several years, using 2018 as the baseline year. The model controls for both team-level and year-level fixed effects and uses clustered standard errors to account for within-team correlation. Compared to 2018, attendance at treated games was not significantly different in 2017 or 2019, with estimated declines of 631 and 817 fans per game, respectively, both statistically insignificant ($p > 0.26$). However, the results reveal statistically significant declines in 2022 and 2023. In 2022, attendance was approximately 4,749 fans lower than in 2018 ($p < 0.001$), and in 2023, it was about 3,156 fans lower ($p < 0.001$). In sharp contrast, 2024 shows a large and statistically significant increase in attendance: an estimated 7,494 more fans per game relative to 2018 ($p < 0.001$). These findings suggest that attendance had declined in the years leading up to 2024. This means that Kelsey Mitchell may not have generated a significant or sustained boost in fan turnout following her 2018 draft year, as attendance remained flat or declined through 2019, 2022, and 2023. While she is certainly a superstar in the WNBA, not all superstars seem to have the same draw or influence.

Discussion

This study explores how the presence of superstar players influences attendance at home games by estimating both immediate and longer-term effects. Using a combination of event study models, lead-lag regressions, and dynamic treatment effect estimation within a panel data framework, the analysis identifies patterns in game-level

attendance across multiple seasons, focusing on changes before and after high-profile player acquisitions.

Results from the event study model shows that some players have the ability to generate an instant and widespread fan response, potentially due to factors like media attention, public recognition, or pre-existing fan bases. In contrast, other player acquisitions appear to have little to no effect, or even a short-term decline, in attendance, followed by a slow and less impactful recovery. This variation highlights that not all players, even those considered stars, have the same draw or commercial influence.

The lead-lag analysis adds further context by tracking attendance changes over several years before and after each player's acquisition. In some cases, a consistent upward trajectory is observed leading into and continuing through the player’s arrival, suggesting that the player may have amplified existing momentum. In other cases, attendance remains flat or declines, showing that the presence of a talented player alone does not guarantee more fan engagement.

Dynamic treatment effect estimation reinforces these findings by comparing year-specific effects across multiple seasons relative to baseline years. Significant differences in attendance are observed in the years before and after specific player arrivals, confirming that the impact is not uniform across time. Some players coincide with steep increases in attendance, while others show no measurable effect or a decline, even when accounting for team- and league-level factors.

Together, these results suggest that while athletic performance is important, a player's influence on attendance is shaped by a combination of factors, including visibility, media narratives, cultural resonance, and timing. The findings have important implications for teams, leagues, and marketers: investing in highly visible players who resonate with fans may yield substantial returns not only in on-court success but in audience growth as well.

Conclusion

This study investigates the impact of superstar players on WNBA attendance, using the Indiana Fever and the high-profile draftings of Caitlin Clark (2024) and Kelsey Mitchell (2018) as case studies. Across three empirical strategies—event study regressions, lead-lag analysis, and dynamic treatment effect estimation—the results consistently demonstrate that Clark's arrival led to an immediate and substantial increase in game attendance, whereas Mitchell's drafting did not yield a comparable effect. These findings suggest that not all superstars generate the same level of public interest and that factors such as media attention, collegiate popularity, and fan anticipation significantly shape the commercial impact of a player.

These insights matter for teams, marketers, and league officials. In a league where attendance and revenue growth remain central to long-term viability, identifying and supporting players with not only athletic skill but also broad fan appeal can help shape strategic planning around branding, scheduling, and media exposure. Policymakers within the league might also consider how to better leverage these high-profile athletes through national campaigns, targeted market outreach, or enhanced broadcasting partnerships.

There are limitations to this study. Data for the 2020 season were excluded due to pandemic disruptions, and 2021 attendance for the Indiana Fever was missing. The analysis also focuses on a single team, which may limit generalizability. Future research could expand this work by assessing additional metrics such as merchandise sales, social media engagement, or viewership figures to develop a fuller understanding of superstar impact across the WNBA.

Overall, this paper highlights the unique role of superstar players in elevating visibility, engagement, and economic outcomes in professional sports.

References

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Montgomery, S. S., & Robinson, M. (2013). Women's attendance at sports events. In *The Economic Efficiency of Sport: International Advances in Economic Research* (pp. [chapter/pages if available]). Edward Elgar Publishing. https://econpapers.repec.org/bookchap/elgeechap/14272_5f1.htm

Appendix

- Put all of your graphs in there!

PUBLICATION STYLE REGRESSION TABLES

Notes:

- What happens if a superstar LEAVES a team?
- Superstar Extinction; Graff Zivin
    - ***Citation***: Azoulay, P., Zivin, J. S. G., & Wang, J. (2010). SUPERSTAR EXTINCTION. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *125*(2), 549–589. http://www.jstor.org/stable/27867490
    - Exploring the Mechanisms Behind Superstar Impact
        - In your case, a player's influence might not only stem from their athletic prowess but also from their **cultural and social capital**. For example, a player like Caitlin Clark might bring along social networks, media presence, or fan base that contribute significantly to higher attendance. Exploring these **non-performance factors** could parallel the *Superstar Extinction* paper's focus on social and intellectual proximity in collaboration.
- Understanding the WNBA on and off the court (https://econpapers.repec.org/bookchap/elgeechap/14272_5f7.htm)
    - ***Citation***: Berri, D., & Krautmann, A. C. (2013). *Understanding the WNBA on and off the court*. https://econpapers.repec.org/bookchap/elgeechap/14272_5f7.htm
    - **Financial Challenges and Revenue Streams**: The paper outlines the financial struggles the WNBA faces, including the league's dependence on NBA owners for support and the challenges in increasing profitability.
        - **Application to Your Research**: By understanding the **economic challenges** of the WNBA, you can explore how the **presence of a superstar** might impact the league's **financial stability** through increased **ticket sales**, **media deals**, or **sponsorships**. Superstars

can potentially boost the league's revenue, which in turn could affect how the WNBA allocates resources for marketing, talent development, and other areas that influence attendance.

- **Stagnant Attendance Patterns**: The paper notes that WNBA attendance peaked in the league's early years and has since stagnated. Despite promotional efforts, attendance has remained around 8,000 fans per game on average.
    - **Application to Your Research**: You can compare **attendance trends** before and after the arrival of superstar players (e.g., Caitlin Clark, Sabrina Ionescu) to see if **superstars help break the stagnation** in attendance. Do superstars generate **significant boosts in attendance** over the long term, or do they only produce **short-term spikes**? This insight could help you understand the sustainability of a superstar's impact on game attendance.
- **Competitive Balance in the WNBA**: The paper discusses how the WNBA has more **competitive balance** compared to the NBA, meaning that teams are generally more competitive throughout the season.
    - **Application to Your Research**: You could explore whether **superstars** help improve or disrupt **competitive balance** in terms of fan engagement. For example, does the presence of a superstar lead to **increased fan interest** in certain teams, especially those that might not typically be successful? Or, do superstars concentrate fan interest on a few dominant teams, leaving others with fewer fans? By examining how the competitive balance is impacted by superstar players, you can assess how **fan behavior** correlates with **team performance** and **star power**.
- **Media Influence on Player Perception**: The paper discusses how media sometimes **overemphasizes** certain players based on their scoring ability, regardless of their actual contributions to team success.
    - **Application to Your Research**: The difference between **media narratives** and actual **on-court performance** can help you assess

how much of the **increase in attendance** is driven by the **media's portrayal** of a superstar versus their actual performance on the court. For instance, does the **media's focus** on a player like Caitlin Clark or Sabrina Ionescu create a **perception of superstar status** that drives attendance, even if their performance doesn't completely match the hype? This will allow you to separate **media-driven fan engagement** from **true player performance**, giving you a clearer picture of how **superstar marketing** influences attendance.

- Women's attendance at sports events (https://econpapers.repec.org/bookchap/elgeechap/14272_5f1.htm)
    - ***Citation***: Montgomery, S. S., & Robinson, M. (2013). *Women's attendance at sports events*. https://econpapers.repec.org/bookchap/elgeechap/14272_5f1.htm
    - **Sports Capital and Engagement**: It offers a framework for analyzing how fans' **sports knowledge and participation** affect their likelihood of attending games when a superstar player is involved.
    - **Gender and Demographics**: The findings about **gendered patterns** in sports attendance can help you understand how **superstar players** influence attendance across different **demographic groups**, particularly women.
- Quitters Never Win: The (Adverse) Incentive Effects of Competing with Superstars; Jennfier Brown
    - ***Citation***: Brown, J. (2011). Quitters Never Win: The (Adverse) Incentive Effects of Competing with Superstars. *Journal of Political Economy*, *119*(5), 982–1013. https://doi.org/10.1086/663306
    - Theoretical Insights on Superstar Influence
        - **Psychological Impact of Superstars**: The paper demonstrates that the presence of a superstar (like Tiger Woods) can **discourage effort** from competitors, especially those with lower skill levels. For your research, you could draw parallels with how the **presence of superstars** (e.g., Caitlin Clark or other prominent

WNBA players) may **influence fans' attendance**. Just as competitors might feel demotivated when facing a superstar, you could explore whether the **expectation of a superstar's dominance** makes fans less likely to attend games if they believe the outcome is predetermined or too one-sided.

- **Fan Behavior**: While the Brown paper focuses on competitors' efforts, you could theorize about the **psychological effect** on fans. For instance, does the presence of a highly marketable superstar increase **enthusiasm** and attendance because fans are eager to witness something extraordinary, or does it create a sense of **inevitability** where attendance dips if fans feel the outcome is too certain?
- **Superstar Effect and Marketability**: The paper shows that the presence of a superstar (like Tiger Woods) affects how other players perform, especially during the superstar's **peak performance periods** (streaks). This insight could be used to examine **how the marketability** and **visibility of a superstar** impact **fan attendance**. You could investigate whether superstars increase attendance when they’re performing at their peak (e.g., a high-scoring season) and whether attendance decreases during periods of lower performance or **"slumps"**.

- **Fan Base and Media Attention**: Similar to how a superstar’s performance affects competitors' strategies, the impact of a superstar on **fan attendance** might vary based on **media attention** and **public interest**. The paper's suggestion that the superstar effect varies depending on the player's performance streak could also be adapted to analyze **how the media attention around a superstar** correlates with changes in **game attendance**.